

ALFORD TOMBSTONE
OAK HILL

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There's a grave monument in the Oak Knoll cemetery in Bellville which a lot of folks wonder about if they ever really notice it. It's a tall marble shaft which supports the almost life size figure of a beautiful ^{young} woman holding a small child in her arms. Under the woman's bare feet is a snake. as if

"Funny thing to have on a grave", some will say.

But there's a genuine good story about this headstone and the lady whose name is carved upon it and how it got to be in the Oak Knoll cemetery under that big clump of pine trees.

Rosa Hill wife of Edgar P. Alford
born March 29, 1875, died January 17, 1899.

These simple facts tell little about the young woman whose grave rests under the marker.

I heard the story one Sunday, from a lady in my church. We were talking about things in general - the way you do after church and she said something about going up to Cisco for a family reunion.

My ears perked up at that because my ^{parents} ~~folks~~ had lived in Cisco when they were young, long before they moved up to Oklahoma. My dad had played trombone in the Cisco brass band, known as "Cisco's Pride." We still have the picture of him and all the other band members in their fancy uniforms posed stiffly, in two neat rows with a big bass drum placed in the middle of the picture. Painted on the face of the drum in old fashioned letters are the words "JUDAH'S BAND, CISCO."

Judah was the name of the bandmaster or director as they are called today.

Anyway, I had heard mention of Cisco off and on in my days as a kid growing up, especially about the band my dad had played in. When I told the lady that my parents had lived in Cisco we got to comparing names and dates and all of a sudden she asked,

"Do you know the story about the ^{young} woman who's buried here in Oak Knoll that had her coffin and marker brought back to Bellville from Cisco?"

When I said no I hadn't heard the story but would sure like to, this is what I was told.

The names and dates may not be just as exact as they should be but back in the 1890's this young lady named Rosa Hill lived in Bellville with her family. She met a young man from Cisco, Texas, ^{Edgar before} who courted her and won her heart. They married and moved to Cisco soon thereafter. They had a small farm out from town and were soon involved in trying to make crops just as all their neighbors were. They worked hard fighting the uncertainties of Texas weather, going into town once in a while for supplies. Rosa worked alongside of Edgar doing the many things it took to keep a farm going. She got pregnant after a year or so and had a beautiful baby son. The little boy became the center of both their lives. Whenever Rosa would go outdoors she would carry the baby on her hip. Feeding the chickens, or taking freshly washed clothes off the line the little boy often rode momma's hip. ~~The baby~~ He was about four months old and still nursing on mother's milk.

One morning after her weekly wash had dried Rosa went out to bring the ~~wash~~ ^{clothes} off of the line. She was barefooted, the baby was sleeping so she went out into the hot dust of the yard. A big diamond back rattle snake had picked a spot under her clothes line to sun itself. She didn't see the snake ~~since~~ ^{as} she was busy feeling the laundry and she

stepped right on it... It hit her leg quicker than she could move and the damage was done.

The story doesn't say anything about her being treated by a doctor but its plain that she nursed her baby after being bitten. The snakes poison killed the mother and the baby. They were buried in the local cemetery in Cisco.

The father ordered a statue carved of his baby boy in his wifes arms with the snake at her feet. This was to be a monument of his love.

The tombstone had to be carved back east ^{someplace} where they had the artisans who were talented enough to do the work. It took over a year to have the marker carved and shipped all the way to Cisco. By the time the marker arrived in its wooden crate and was set off the train at the freight depot, the husband's grief had been cured by another young woman and he was already re-married.

The marker sat in the freight depot gathering dust and spider webs. When it became evident that the marker would probably continue to stay in the depot and never be taken to the cemetery, someone in Cisco wrote a letter to the parents of the girl and told them about what was going on.

It didn't take long for their ~~parents~~ to go up to Cisco and get a court order from a sympathetic judge to have their daughters ~~and grandchild's~~ bodies brought back to Bellville, along with the full size hand carved statue.

A service was held and the mother ~~and child~~ ^{was} ~~was~~ re-interred with the unusual monument marking the spot.

It's there today just about in the middle of the cemetery. The grave marker faces to the east and when the sun hits it ~~about~~ ^{in the} mid morning, it glows on a ~~figure~~ ^{young woman's} figure dressed in a long flowing gown with a hood over her head.

She is holding the little boy in her arms, on her right side. It doesn't look like you'd expect an early Texas farm girl to look who was out to bring in the washing. She looks more like some Italian sculpture version of the Madonna and Child. One thing that stone carver did do right, ^{through} is that mean looking snake at her feet. It looks like if you stuck out your hand he'd strike you before you knew what hit you.

when the morning sun splashes it with light, it glows on —

What about the baby boy? Was his body moved also or was it left behind.

No one seems to know.